

FORUM



MERCATUS

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1. Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Stakeholders,

Welcome to Forum Mercatus, the Economic Committee of the Good Earth School Youth Conclave 2026 (GESYC'26).

Every generation is defined by the opportunities it creates for its youth. Today, India stands at a remarkable crossroads—home to one of the world's youngest populations, yet confronted by a question that will shape its economic future: *How do we ensure that every young person willing to work has a fair opportunity to do so?*

Youth unemployment is not merely a statistic buried within economic reports. It is the engineering graduate whose qualifications no longer match industry demands. It is the student uncertain whether today's degree will remain relevant tomorrow. It is the young woman weighing professional aspirations against societal expectations and caregiving responsibilities. It is the person with a disability seeking not sympathy, but an equal chance to contribute. *Behind every percentage lies a story, a challenge, and a future waiting to be realised.*

This year's agenda, **"Addressing Youth Unemployment in a Changing Economy,"** invites you to move beyond surface-level discussions and explore the structural realities shaping India's labour market. Rapid technological advancement, automation, evolving employer expectations, the widening gap between education and employability, demographic shifts, and unequal access to opportunities have transformed the nature of work itself. Your task is not simply to identify these challenges—but to understand how they intersect and to craft solutions that are **practical, inclusive, and sustainable.**

Unlike traditional conferences, Forum Mercatus does not ask you to represent nations. Instead, you will assume the role of those who shape, influence, and experience India's employment landscape every day—policymakers, industry leaders, educational institutions, young job seekers, women returning to the workforce, labour economists, and persons with disabilities. Each stakeholder enters the discussion with distinct priorities, responsibilities, and constraints. Meaningful progress will depend not on individual advocacy alone, but on **negotiation, collaboration, and the ability to balance competing interests** in pursuit of a common objective.

We encourage you to approach this committee with intellectual curiosity, evidence-based reasoning, and empathy. Challenge prevailing assumptions. Engage with perspectives beyond your own. Recognise that *the most enduring solutions are often born where differing viewpoints converge.*

As you enter Forum Mercatus, remember that your deliberations are not simply an academic exercise—they are a reflection of conversations taking place across boardrooms, classrooms, ministries, and households throughout the nation. The ideas developed within this committee should aspire to be **ambitious enough to inspire and practical enough to implement.**

We look forward to two days of thoughtful debate, meaningful collaboration, and innovative policymaking as we work together to

2. Rules of Procedure

Please refer to the official GESYC'26 Rules of Procedure manual, available in the same Google Drive folder as this background guide, for the full Rules of Procedure governing this committee.

3. About Forum Mercatus

Forum Mercatus is a committee built differently. Instead of delegates representing countries, it brings together the real stakeholders of India's job market, government ministries, industry, colleges, and job seekers themselves, to work out practical solutions to one big problem: **youth unemployment in India.**

3.1 Vision and Objective

The vision behind Forum Mercatus is simple to say and hard to achieve: **a country where every young person who wants to work can find work worth doing.** Getting there needs honest conversations between the people who make policy, the people who create jobs, the people who train the workforce, and the young people who are actually searching for that first opportunity.

Over five sessions, this committee will build toward that vision by wrestling with five open questions. We will not hand you the answers here, that is exactly what the room is for.

- **Why are young people unemployed?** The easy answer is "not enough jobs." The real answer is messier, and worth arguing about.
- **Which sectors can create the jobs of tomorrow?** Everyone at this table will have a favourite answer, solar power, AI, gig platforms. Not everyone will agree, and that disagreement is where the real debate starts.
- **What skills will future employers demand?** Ask a college and a company this question, and you will likely get two very different answers. This committee has to reconcile them.
- **Which policies can accelerate sustainable employment?** There is no shortage of schemes on paper in India. The harder question is whether they are actually working, and for whom.
- **Why are government jobs vacant but not getting filled?** *Lakhs of sanctioned government posts sit empty even as lakhs of applicants queue up for them every year.* Figuring out why is this session's real puzzle.

3.2 Stakeholders / Members of the Committee

Forum Mercatus brings together 32 delegates across the following 14 stakeholder portfolios, each with their own interests and priorities:

- Engineering Student -2
- Medical Student -2
- Arts & Humanities Student -1
- Young Job Seeker -4
- Woman Returning to the Workforce -3

3.2 Stakeholders / Members of the Committee

- Company CEO's-2
- Corporate HR / Recruiter-2
- Startup Founder-2
- Educational Institutions-2
- Government Recruitment Official-2

3.3 Expected Outcome

By the end of the sessions, delegates are expected to produce a clear Policy Blueprint aimed at:

- Creating employment opportunities for India's youth
- Building stronger links between education, industry, and government
- Promoting fair and inclusive hiring practices
- Building a workforce ready for a fast-changing economy

4. Agenda

"Addressing Youth Unemployment in a Changing Economy"

4.1 Why this agenda matters

Picture two Indias existing at the same time. In one, the economy is among the fastest-growing of any major nation, new expressways are being built, start-ups are being funded, and stock markets keep hitting new highs. In the other, a 24-year-old engineering graduate has just sent out application number three hundred and heard nothing back. Both of these are real, and both are happening right now. That gap, between an economy that is visibly growing and a generation that cannot always find work in it, is what this agenda is about.

Government data (the Periodic Labour Force Survey, 2025) shows India's overall unemployment rate is around 3.1 per cent. But unemployment among youth (15-29 years) is far higher, at 9.9 per cent, and worse still in cities, at 13.6 per cent. **About one in four young Indians is neither working, studying, nor learning a skill.**

India is often described as sitting on a "demographic dividend," more working-age people than dependents, in theory a huge economic advantage over ageing economies elsewhere in the world. But a dividend only pays out if there are enough jobs to go around. Right now, for a meaningful share of India's youth, *that dividend is sitting uncashed.*

The picture is shifting even further. Automation and Artificial Intelligence are changing which jobs exist at all, while new sectors like solar energy, electric vehicles, and other green industries are growing quickly. **If young Indians are not ready for these changes, they risk being left behind even as new jobs appear elsewhere in the same economy.**

4.2 Why this agenda matters to Forum Mercatus

So who is actually responsible for a jobless graduate? The university that

- Colleges blame companies for narrow, rigid hiring criteria. Companies blame colleges for outdated curricula. Government blames both for not making full use of the schemes already on offer. Job seekers, understandably, feel blamed by everyone and heard by no one. Forum Mercatus exists to interrupt this cycle. It brings together the government ministries that design policy, the industry voices that create jobs and set skill requirements, the educational institutions that train the workforce, and the job seekers who live with the results of every decision made above their heads.
- This agenda asks the committee to stop assigning blame and instead build something that actually works, a plan specific enough to survive contact with reality, and fair enough that no single stakeholder walks away having won at everyone else's expense.

5. Understanding Youth Unemployment in India

5.1 Why are young Indians unemployed?

Youth unemployment rarely has just one cause. The Executive Board asks delegates to think about the following connected reasons:

- **Jobless growth:** India's economy is growing, but not always creating enough good jobs to match. Growth in some sectors does not need many workers.
- **Skill mismatch:** Colleges often teach one thing while companies need another. India's skill gap is estimated at 30-40 per cent of the workforce (India Employment Report, 2024).
- **Automation and AI:** Basic office jobs, like data entry and simple accounting, are shrinking fast as AI takes over routine tasks. These were often the first jobs young people got.
- **Too many young workers, not enough jobs:** India adds millions of young people to its workforce every year, more than the economy can currently absorb.
- **No job without experience:** Companies want experienced workers, but young people cannot gain experience without a first job. This traps many first-time job seekers.
- **Informal jobs:** Many young Indians who do find work end up in informal jobs, with no job security, no benefits, and low pay.

5.2 The situation in India today

The Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) 2025 shows India's overall unemployment rate holding steady at around 3.1 per cent. But youth unemployment (15-29 years) is far higher, at 9.9 per cent in 2025 (down slightly from 10.3 per cent in 2024). The gap between cities and villages is large: 8.3 per cent in rural areas compared to 13.6 per cent in urban areas. About a quarter of India's youth are not working, studying or learning any skill at all, showing that India is not yet

6. Sectors and Skills for India's Future

6.1 Which sectors can create jobs in India?

Not every growing sector is a good source of jobs, some grow through machines and capital rather than people. Genuine possible engines of youth employment in India:

- **Green and renewable energy:** Solar power, wind energy, electric vehicles, waste management, and sustainable construction could create 35-50 million green jobs in India by 2047-2070. Electric vehicles alone could create up to 10 million direct and 50 million indirect jobs by 2030. However, women currently hold only 11-12 per cent of green jobs, and about 40 per cent of new green jobs are coming up outside big metros, a real chance to spread opportunity to smaller towns and cities.
- **Digital, technology, and AI jobs:** India's technology industry continues to create demand for roles in AI, data, cybersecurity, and fintech, though these usually need strong technical training.
- **Gig and platform work:** India's gig workforce stood at about 7.7 million workers in 2020 and is expected to nearly triple to 23.5 million by 2029-30 (NITI Aayog). This offers flexible entry points for young workers, but raises real questions about job security, benefits, and social protection.
- **Manufacturing and "Make in India":** Government incentives for electronics, semiconductors, and advanced manufacturing aim to create formal jobs, though these often need higher technical skills than older factory jobs.
- **The care economy:** Healthcare, elder care, and childcare are fast-growing sectors that are often informal and undervalued, but important, especially for women's employment.

6.2 What skills will Indian employers look for?

Industry surveys in India consistently point to two kinds of skills. First, technical and digital skills: comfort with AI tools, basic data literacy, and familiarity with new workplace technology are becoming baseline expectations, not bonus skills. Second, durable human skills: critical thinking, adaptability, communication, and a genuine willingness to keep learning are what set candidates apart once the basic technical bar is met.

For India, the real gap to close is vocational training. Only about 4.2 per cent of India's workforce currently holds a formal vocational qualification, despite most young Indians completing at least secondary education. This points to an urgent need for hands-on, industry-linked training built into schools and colleges, through apprenticeships, internships, and stronger sector skill councils that connect classroom learning to what employers actually need.

7. Policies for Sustainable Employment in India

Delegates representing government stakeholders should know the major policies already in motion. Any Policy Blueprint will likely build on, improve, or expand these, rather than start from scratch:

- **PM Internship Scheme (2024-present):** A 12-month internship for youth aged 21-24 at India's top 500 companies, with a monthly stipend of Rs. 5,000 and a one-time grant of Rs. 6,000. It gives priority to SC, ST, OBC candidates and persons with disabilities, and aims to provide one crore (10 million) internships as part of the government's wider Employment and

8. Making Growth Work for Every Indian

Growth that does not reach everyone is incomplete. This section looks at three groups whose employment challenges this committee must address directly.

8.1 Women returning to the workforce

PLFS 2025 data shows a large gender gap in India's workforce: 79.1 per cent of men take part in the labour force, compared to only 40.0 per cent of women. Among women who are not working, 44.4 per cent say childcare or household duties are the main reason, compared to 69.8 per cent of men who say they are still studying. The real obstacles are not a lack of ambition or qualification, they are unpaid care work at home, safety concerns, inflexible work hours, and a lack of support for women returning after a career break.

8.2 Persons with disabilities seeking employment

Persons with disabilities in India continue to face very low employment rates. The reasons include workplaces that are physically hard to access, bias among employers, a lack of assistive technology, and weak enforcement of laws like the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016. Newer schemes, like the PM Internship Scheme, now give priority to persons with disabilities during selection, a model this committee may want to study and expand.

8.3 Informal jobs and job security

A large share of India's workforce, including many young workers, is in informal jobs with no fixed pay, no job security, and no social security cover. As gig and platform work grows quickly, this problem is becoming even more urgent to address. The committee should think about how social protection can be extended to these newer forms of work, without removing the flexibility that makes them appealing to young workers in the first place.

9. Steps Already Taken in India

The following actions are already in place and are directly relevant to this agenda. Delegates may build on them, or point out where they fall short:

- Union Budget 2024-25 Employment and Skilling Package: A set of five schemes, including the PM Internship Scheme, aimed directly at reducing youth unemployment through skilling, apprenticeship support, and first-job incentives.
- Skill India Mission / PMKVY: India's flagship vocational training programme, described in Section 7.
- National Education Policy (NEP) 2020: Building vocational and skills-based learning into schools and colleges from an early stage.
- Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016: India's main law requiring reservation, accessibility, and anti-discrimination

10. Stakeholder Positions

This committee does not ask you to represent a country's foreign policy. Instead, you represent the real interests, worries, and limits of a stakeholder portfolio. The notes below are a detailed starting point, but delegates are strongly encouraged to research further and sharpen their own position beyond what is written here

Engineering Student

Represents students in one of India's largest and most competitive higher-education streams. Their core interest is a curriculum that actually keeps pace with a fast-changing technical world, and a real shot at core-sector or technical roles after graduation. They worry about India producing far more engineering graduates each year than there are matching technical jobs, and about ending up, like a large share of engineering graduates already do, in a role that has little to do with their degree. Expect this stakeholder to push for updated, industry-linked curricula, meaningful (not token) internships, and stronger direct pipelines between colleges and technical employers. Likely tension: with educational institutions over how fast curricula can realistically change, and with corporate HR over entry-level experience demands that feel impossible to meet straight out of college.

Medical Student

Represents students in medical, nursing, and allied health pipelines. Their core interest is enough postgraduate and residency seats, and a realistic path into India's public or private healthcare workforce after years of demanding study. They worry about seat shortages, the unpopularity of rural postings despite acute rural healthcare needs, and a strange contradiction at the heart of this agenda: thousands of sanctioned government medical posts remain vacant even as far more medical graduates compete for far fewer training seats. Expect this stakeholder to push for expanded postgraduate seats, better incentives for rural service, and closer coordination between health workforce planning and this committee's employment agenda. Likely tension: with the Ministry of Finance over funding new medical posts, and with the Government Recruitment Official over recruitment processes that move far slower than the healthcare system's actual staffing needs.

Arts & Humanities Student

Represents students in non-technical fields, humanities, social sciences, commerce, and the creative arts. Their core interest is challenging the assumption that only STEM degrees lead to real employment, and gaining genuine access to jobs in media, design, communications, public policy, and the wider creative and care economies. They worry about being treated as an afterthought in skilling and internship schemes that lean heavily technical, and about a public conversation on "employability" that rarely mentions their fields at all. Expect this stakeholder to push for humanities-linked sectors to be formally recognised as legitimate job creators, and for

Young Job Seeker

The largest bloc in this committee, representing job seekers who have already left education and are actively hunting for that first real job, across sectors and backgrounds. Their core interest is a fair, transparent shot at employment regardless of where they studied or who they know. They worry about the "experience trap" (no job without experience, no experience without a job), about ending up in informal work with no security, and about having to relocate to afford any real opportunity at all. Expect this stakeholder to push for transparent hiring practices, wider access to internships and apprenticeships outside major metros, and portable social security for gig and informal work. Likely tension: with corporate HR over hiring bias toward urban or well-networked candidates, and with government stakeholders over whether existing schemes are actually reaching people like them.

Woman Returning to the Workforce

Represents women who paused their careers for caregiving and are now seeking to re-enter paid work. Their core interest is flexible roles, safe workplaces, and employers who are genuinely open to hiring after a career gap. They worry about being seen as "risky hires," the lack of affordable childcare, and being pushed into lower-paid or informal roles regardless of their prior experience and qualifications. Expect this stakeholder to push for workplace creche support, flexible or hybrid work options, structured "returnship" programmes, and legal protection against career-gap discrimination. Likely tension: with corporate HR and startup founders over who bears the cost of care-friendly infrastructure, and with government over whether that cost should be subsidised or mandated on employers.

Person with Disability Seeking Employment

Represents job seekers with physical, sensory, intellectual, or other disabilities. Their core interest is genuine access to jobs, not token compliance with reservation quotas. They worry about inaccessible workplaces, employer bias often disguised as vague "cultural fit" concerns, and quotas that are met on paper but not in spirit. Expect this stakeholder to push for real enforcement of the RPwD Act, assistive technology support, accessible workplace audits, and disability-confident hiring training for employers and HR teams. Likely tension: with corporate HR and startup founders over the cost of accessibility retrofits, and with government over weak monitoring of quota compliance.

Rural Youth Representative

Represents young job seekers from rural and semi-urban India, where both jobs and training infrastructure are scarcer than in big cities. Their core interest is real opportunity that does not require relocating to a metro just to find decent work. They worry that most new-economy jobs, IT, fintech, corporate roles, remain clustered in a handful of large cities, while rural training centres and ITIs are

Ministry of Labour & Employment / Labour Economist

Represents the government body responsible for employment policy, labour law, and workforce data. Their core interest is hitting employment generation targets and being able to show credible results. They worry most about schemes that look good on paper but fail on the ground, and about being blamed for "jobless growth" even when the ministry does not control overall economic growth. Expect this stakeholder to push for better implementation and monitoring of existing schemes, formalisation of informal jobs, and closer coordination across ministries. Likely tension: with the Ministry of Finance over how much to spend on employment schemes, and with corporate HR and startup founders over enforcement of labour codes that companies see as an added compliance burden.

Ministry of Finance

Represents the government's fiscal discipline and budget-setting arm. Their core interest is sustainable public spending within a responsible budget. They worry about employment schemes turning into permanent, ever-growing subsidies without matching results, and about fiscal deficit targets slipping. Expect this stakeholder to push for time-bound schemes, private-sector-led job creation, and clear cost-benefit evidence before any programme is expanded. Likely tensions: with the Ministry of Labour, which will always want a bigger budget, and with the Government Recruitment Official over funding to fill sanctioned but vacant posts more quickly.

Company CEOs

Represents the top leadership of established companies who hire at scale across sectors, not the day-to-day recruiters, but the executives who set overall headcount, budget, and hiring strategy. Their core interest is workforce productivity and cost efficiency at a company-wide level, alongside a public image that holds up under scrutiny when youth unemployment becomes a national talking point. They worry about labour law changes that raise fixed costs, about being publicly blamed for not "hiring enough" when many roles genuinely have no qualified applicants, and about competing with startups and global companies for the same limited pool of specialised talent. Expect this stakeholder to push for predictable, business-friendly regulation, tax incentives tied to net job creation, and a bigger say in shaping national skilling priorities. Likely tension: with the Ministry of Labour over compliance costs, and with corporate HR and startup founders, who often want the same policy levers pulled in different directions depending on company size.

Corporate HR / Recruiter

Represents the people actually responsible for hiring decisions inside established companies. Their core interest is filling roles quickly with candidates who need minimal additional training, while keeping the cost per hire under control. They worry about the skills gap slowing down their own hiring pipelines, about public criticism when roles go

Startup Founder

Represents India's newer, more agile employers in the startup and new-economy ecosystem. Their core interest is quick access to specific, in-demand technical talent, AI, data, fintech, green tech, without the hiring bureaucracy that larger companies can absorb more easily. They worry about shallow talent pools in cutting-edge skills, the cost of training freshers when the company itself is cash-constrained, and policy that lumps all "corporate" employers together when a ten-person startup has very different resources from a large established firm. Expect this stakeholder to push for startup-specific hiring incentives, direct pipelines with colleges for specialised talent, and lighter compliance requirements for smaller employers. Likely tension: with the Ministry of Finance and Ministry of Labour over regulatory burden, and with corporate HR over competing for the same small pool of specialised graduates.

Educational Institutions

Represents schools, colleges, universities, and vocational training bodies. Their core interest has traditionally been academic reputation, but is increasingly measured by placement outcomes. They worry about being asked to overhaul curricula faster than funding, faculty training, or accreditation processes allow, and about losing academic autonomy to industry-dictated syllabi. Expect this stakeholder to push for funding for faculty upskilling, public-private partnerships for labs and equipment, and phased, realistic curriculum reform rather than abrupt overhaul. Likely tension: with corporate HR and startup founders over the pace of change, and with students across portfolios who understandably want faster results than institutions can always deliver.

Government Recruitment Official

Represents the officials who run recruitment processes for government jobs at the Union or state level. Their core interest is filling sanctioned vacancies efficiently while protecting the credibility of the selection process itself. This portfolio sits at the centre of the agenda's sharpest question: why do lakhs of sanctioned government posts remain vacant every year even as lakhs of applicants queue up for them? Real pressures behind this include slow, litigation-prone selection processes, delayed budget approvals for filling sanctioned posts, examination-paper leaks and re-tests that can delay a single recruitment cycle by years, and the sheer administrative scale of hiring for a country the size of India. Expect this stakeholder to push for streamlined and genuinely time-bound recruitment cycles, better-resourced recruiting bodies, and secure, tamper-proof examination systems. Likely tension: with young job seekers and rural youth representatives, who experience these delays as years of their working life lost waiting for a post that may never be filled in time, and with the Ministry of Finance over budget sanction delays.

11. Key Questions for the Policy Blueprint

The Executive Board gives you five questions to keep in mind, matching the five sessions of this committee:

- 1) Why are young Indians unemployed, and which of these causes can policy realistically fix?
- 2) Which sectors can realistically create jobs in India, and how can stakeholders speed up job creation in them?
- 3) What skills will Indian employers look for, and how should schools, colleges, and training systems change to deliver them?
- 4) Which policies can create more secure, formal jobs for young Indians, faster?
- 5) Why are government jobs vacant but not getting filled?

12. A Short Note on Crisis Situations

Crisis situations in Forum Mercatus are governed by Stage IV ("Stress Test") of the official GESYC'26 Rules of Procedure, please refer to the ROP manual in the same Google Drive folder for the full mechanics of Crisis Simulations, Press Conferences, Public Opinion Review, Budget Adjustments, and the Tomorrow Morning Test.

In brief: a crisis tests how well you can adapt and negotiate under pressure while staying true to your stakeholders' real interests. There is no single correct response; what matters is whether your reaction is realistic for your portfolio and whether you can still work with other stakeholders while defending your own interests.

Come prepared not just with research, but with the judgement to think on your feet.

13. Conclusion

Here is what we, the Executive Board, actually want from you. We want you to walk in having read this guide properly, not skimmed it, and to have gone one step further with your own research into your stakeholder's real interests. Know your portfolio's real pressures, its constraints, and its usual allies and rivals before you take your seat.

We want you to argue for your stakeholder's interests honestly, even when it is inconvenient. An industry representative who pretends to prioritise absolute affordability over their own margins is not being diplomatic, they are being dishonest. But we also want you to genuinely listen to other stakeholders and be willing to change your position when a better argument is made. Good debate is not about repeating your talking points louder, it is about testing your position against someone else's and adjusting it when needed.

We want your final Policy Blueprint to be specific. "The government should create more jobs" is not a policy. A proposal that names a scheme, a budget, a target, and a timeline is. Vague, feel-good language will not impress this Board; specific, defensible, and realistic ideas will.

We want to see delegates who treat every stakeholder at this table, including the ones with the least power, the young job seeker, the woman returning to work, the person with a disability, as seriously as the ministries and corporations. A Policy Blueprint that only works for the powerful stakeholders in the room has failed the actual agenda. Most of all, we want you to leave this committee having genuinely thought harder about a problem that will, in a few years, affect many of you directly. Come prepared, argue well, listen honestly, and build something real.

All the very best, we look forward to seeing what you bring to the table.

Sincerely,
The Executive Board – Forum Mercatus
GESYC'26

14. Plausible Sources

Here is a list of credible Indian sources that will help with your research:

14.1 Government data and reports

- Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI): mospi.gov.in
- NITI Aayog: niti.gov.in
- Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship: msde.gov.in
- PM Internship Scheme portal: pminternship.mca.gov.in
- Press Information Bureau (PIB): pib.gov.in

14.2 Credible media and research organisations

- The Hindu, Livemint, Business Standard, Forbes India, Times of India
- Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE)
- TeamLease and India Skills Report (industry skilling and employability studies)

15. Citations

<https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2246009>
<https://impakter.com/indias-youth-boom-promise-or-pressure-point/>
<https://www.forbesindia.com/article/news/indias-jobless-rate-holds-steady-but-graduates-and-youth-struggle-to-find-work/2992612/1>
<https://www.studyiq.com/articles/unemployment-rate-in-india/>
<https://india.mongabay.com/2025/05/what-are-green-jobs-explainer/>
<https://www.policycircle.org/opinion/green-jobs-sustainability/>
<https://www.ilo.org/publications/expansion-gig-and-platform-economy-india-opportunities-employer-and>
<https://pminternshipscheme.com/>
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Prime_Minister_Internship_Scheme